no answer was ever given to them in response! The special tribunal, they maintained, was not founded on law. An unjust law, they argued, cannot be a basis of peace and stability in society. This was not the same as rejecting the law itself. To say so is to misunderstand what the revolutionaries stood for. It is why they have never really been fully rehabilitated in the Indian consciousness. They have always stood outside it. The best they could achieve was to be seen as a romanticized, impractical and ill-fated group of young men awkwardly attempting to secure India's Independence but sacrificing all for little or no gain to themselves. Yet, the revolutionaries did believe in law but only with the proviso that '[t]he sanctity of law can be maintained only so long as it is the expression of the will of the people' but not otherwise, because '[w]hen it becomes a mere instrument in the hands of an oppressing class it loses sanctity and significance for the fundamental preliminary for the administration of justice is the elimination of every interest'[3].

These words display remarkable foresight. They show these young men to be ahead of their time. It was to be almost another half a century before the call for equal rights and equality of treatment were to arise in the USA. The admonishment that 'as soon as the law ceases to correspond to the popular racial needs, it becomes the means for perpetration of injustice and tyranny' may just as well be one taken from a decision of a constitutional court of a Western democracy today. It was so modern. The demand for the 'elimination of every interest' was a demand for the elimination of 'special' interests in society because these were an obstacle to equal treatment for all under the law. The revolutionaries, therefore, believed that 'the maintaining of such a law is nothing but a hypocritical assertion of a special interest against the common interest'. This is why they did not appear before the special tribunal choosing instead to boycott its proceedings. In hearing the case under the Lahore Ordinance III, the special tribunal could dispense with the attendance of the accused when it wanted. It could even dispense with any of its judges, and two of the three were actually removed at the drop of a hat. Not surprisingly, in a pulverizing statement which allowed for no quarter, the letter of 5 May 1930 thundered, 'The laws of the present